banking on drawn-out negotiations.

They might suggest a reform to the Security Council of the United Nations, currently composed of five permanent members with the right to vote. Yet these negotiations are fraught with conflict because many candidates are vying for the new seat under consideration. Among them are the old powers (Germany, Japan) and those on the rise (India, Brazil). Moreover, neither China nor Russia is convinced of the wisdom of this change. Several sub-powers have also shown an inclination to offer troops for UN missions, thereby providing cover for the hypocrisy of humanitarian imperialism. This conduct not only demonstrates the affinity the dominant classes of these countries feel for the global status quo, it also indicates the difficulties they confront in pursuing alternative paths. Some members on this fringe compete among themselves on various economic terrains and others still maintain old border disputes. And, many times, their strategic priorities do not converge.

For example, the BRICS held various summits in order to agree on specific increases in trade, the creation of a reserve fund, and the eventual constitution of a Development Bank. But they have mostly focused on finding agreements about short-term contingencies and have failed to make progress on significant commitments. These attitudes are determined by the close relationship the dominant classes are nurturing with transnational corporations. They are bourgeois, and have discarded the old pretences of the anti-imperial projects of the 1960s and 1970s. A 'Non-Aligned' bloc or a summit like the one celebrated in Bandung is beyond their horizons. They play their part on the neoliberal stage alongside the multi-millionaire elites who are deeply integrated in the global club of the most powerful. We can see these tendencies at work in the four following cases.

Russia

Russia's recovery is plain to see. The Putin era counteracted the social disintegration, economic collapse and loss of international influence which came in the wake of the USSR's implosion. Yet focusing on the contrasts between these two periods may obscure critical continuities. The Russian president consolidated a new capitalist class, which was forged from the old bureaucracy by means of pillaging state property. The brazen sacking of state property during the Yeltsin period led to the collapse of the rouble.[10]

Putin limited the excesses, restoring order, which was required for capitalism to function. He reconstructed the state's power by means of building an authoritarian machine, based on popular exhaustion with the previous chaotic period. He